

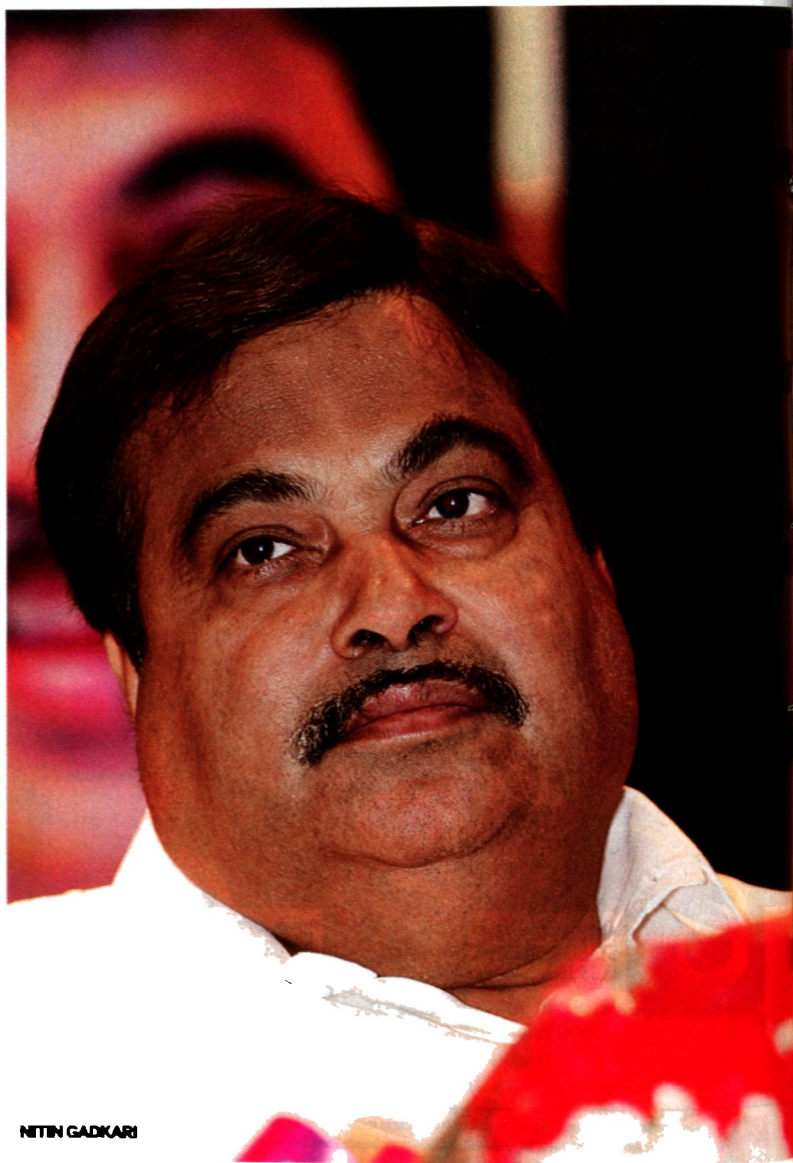
Slippery SLO

Gadkari is considered to be honest and well-meaning but five months into the job, the BJP is

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

The political mess the BJP finds itself embroiled in Jharkhand and the slippery Shibu Soren is becoming symptomatic of the party's fortunes ever since the debacle in election 2009. Worse, it has exposed the party's leadership as effete and ineffective, in particular the man chosen to steer the BJP out of troubled waters. Five months into the top job, he seems to have achieved the opposite. The biggest lesson he has learnt is that good intentions do not always translate into action. The president of the beleaguered BJP, Nitin Gadkari has even earned him the sobriquet of *Sheikh Chilli* from some of his party colleagues. Consumed by his own struggle to break free from the shackles of Vidarbha and go beyond his original avatar of a builder of highways, Gadkari is hardly an inspiring figure for the party. Handpicked by the RSS to lead the BJP and bring about some cohesion in the faction-ridden party, the 53-year-old Gadkari has not given any indication so far that he is the man for the job. In fact, he appears gingerly and hesitant in his approach when it comes to handling senior party leaders. Many of the leaders, whose claims to the top party post were rejected by the RSS, continue to wield considerable clout in the party.

"Unfair," say his indignant but dwindling band of cheerleaders. They claim, it is too early to judge Gadkari—a newcomer on the national scene. So, till the time Gadkari settles down and acquires a national perspective, he skips the blame as the party hurtles from one disaster to another. Considering he is surrounded by all *Marathi Manoos* even in the BJP central



NITIN GADKARI

PHOTOGRAPH BY ANAND K. NARAYAN